

Mistakes Were Made (But Not by Me)

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Corpus priority: Phase 2

Document type: Synthesized RAG source dossier built from publicly available online material

Purpose In This RAG Corpus

- Excellent foundation for self-justification, cognitive dissonance, and escalation of commitment.
- Very useful for leadership failures, investigations, conflict, bad science, and institutional defensiveness.
- Adds psychological depth to why people double down after making harmful or foolish decisions.

Key Concepts And Retrieval Tags

- cognitive_dissonance
- self_justification
- confirmation_bias
- memory_distortion
- escalation_of_commitment
- defensive_reasoning

Core Learnings

- Once people act, they often reshape beliefs and memory to preserve a positive self-image.
- Self-justification is more dangerous than lying because people can sincerely believe their revised account.
- Conflict, bad science, and institutional failure can all be reinforced by a refusal to admit error.
- The book shows how small rationalizations can grow into large-scale harm.
- Owning mistakes requires social and emotional conditions that make revision possible rather than humiliating.

Directions, Observations, And Implications

- Use for leadership, HR, compliance, and conflict scenarios where someone is protecting identity rather than truth.
- Retrieve it when users describe doubling down, rewriting history, or defending bad decisions despite contrary evidence.
- Apply it to recommendations about postmortems, accountability design, and psychologically safer error correction.
- Useful when the system needs to explain why sincere people can become unreliable narrators of their own choices.

How This Can Be Applied In Decision Making

- Use for leadership, HR, compliance, and conflict scenarios where someone is protecting identity rather than truth.

- Retrieve it when users describe doubling down, rewriting history, or defending bad decisions despite contrary evidence.
- Apply it to recommendations about postmortems, accountability design, and psychologically safer error correction.
- Useful when the system needs to explain why sincere people can become unreliable narrators of their own choices.

How This Strengthens A Bias-Aware RAG System

- Improves the corpus for self-justification, stubborn reasoning, and failure to update on evidence.
- Adds nuance to escalation and defensive behavior in both individual and organizational settings.
- Supports recommendations for learning loops, admissions of error, and anti-defensiveness process design.

Limitations And Cautions

- This dossier is based on public summaries and table-of-contents data rather than a full-text analysis.
- The book is psychologically rich and example-heavy, so later expansion with primary excerpts would improve retrieval depth.

Chapter-Wise Summary

- **Cognitive Dissonance: The Engine of Self-justification:** Introduces dissonance as the tension that drives people to defend actions and beliefs rather than revise them.
- **Pride and Prejudice . . . and Other Blind Spots:** Explains how identity, ego, and group loyalties create selective vision and biased interpretation.
- **Memory, the Self-justifying Historian:** Shows how memory gets edited to support preferred self-understandings and protect prior choices.
- **Good Intentions, Bad Science: The Closed Loop of Clinical Judgment:** Examines how professionals can keep trusting flawed methods by insulating themselves from correction.
- **Law and Disorder:** Applies self-justification to legal actors, false confessions, prosecutorial certainty, and justice failures.
- **Love's Assassin: Self-justification in Marriage:** Shows how intimate conflict escalates when both sides reinterpret events to preserve righteousness.
- **Wounds, Rifts, and Wars:** Extends the logic of dissonance to intergroup conflict, polarization, and violence.
- **Letting Go and Owning Up:** Closes with the difficult but necessary work of admitting error and reopening the possibility of learning.

Source Notes

- Open Library summary (library_summary):
https://openlibrary.org/books/OL7362572M/Mistakes_Were_Made_%28But_Not_by_Me%29
- Des Moines Public Library table of contents (table_of_contents):
<https://catalog.dmpl.org/Record/173013>
- Wikipedia overview (overview):
https://en.wikipedia.org/wiki/Mistakes_Were_Made_%28but_Not_by_Me%29

RAG Ingestion Note

This document is intentionally written as a concise, retrieval-friendly synthesis rather than as a book review. It is designed to help the system retrieve named biases and decision failures, practical mitigation methods, organizational and AI-governance implications, and scenario-to-concept mappings for user prompts.